

IMO pick-your-emissions plan week begins

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【要点】

- ・ IMO気候交渉が本日開始され、競合する複数の排出ネットゼロフレームワーク案が提示されており、EU案は2050年までのネットゼロ達成を目指す一方、パナマ・リベリア案は義務的な排出価格設定を廃止するなど大きく異なる。
- ・ ギリシャ海運大臣は、EUの共通立場に署名した直後、EUの準備が柔軟性に欠け、欧州海運の70%以上を占める加盟国の懸念に対応していないと批判し、硬直的なアプローチはIMO合意の可能性を損なうと警告した。
- ・ パナマ・リベリア案は強制的な排出価格設定やネットゼロ基金を廃止し、既に商業的に実現可能な燃料に基づいた排出目標を提案しており、ギリシャの海運業者から公開支持を受けている。
- ・ 中国は、固定的な財政報酬をより一般的な「インセンティブ措置」に置き換えるなど、フレームワークをより柔軟にする修正案を提案し、主要派閥のいずれにも属さない中道的な立場を模索している。

【メール原文】

Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure. By MARTINA SAPIO with JORDYN DAHL SNEAK PEEK — A new round of IMO climate talks

Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure.

By MARTINA SAPIO

with JORDYN DAHL

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SNEAK PEEK

— A new round of IMO climate talks begins today, with governments facing a menu of competing plans for the contested Net-Zero Framework.

— Russia claims its growing shipping traffic in the Arctic is just the beginning.

— Volkswagen's workers union has made clear they're not on board with the management's proposed cost-cutting measures and will fight the plan.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

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DRIVING THE DAY

IMO BUILD-YOUR-PLAN: Governments begin another round of IMO shipping emissions negotiations today with no shortage of alternatives to the contested Net-Zero Framework — ranging from an EU-backed plan that largely preserves the framework’s architecture to proposals that would delay it, loosen its targets or scrap its central pricing mechanism altogether.

EU holds the line: The EU and its allies remain on the ambitious side of the debate, insisting the final rules keep shipping on course for net-zero emissions by or around 2050, use lifecycle emissions accounting and provide incentives for cleaner fuels from the start. Brussels has nevertheless opened the door to amendments addressing other countries’ concerns.

The Greek variant: Days after POLITICO revealed that Greece had signed the EU’s common position on the framework, however, its Shipping Minister Vassilis Kikilias said EU preparations had shown insufficient flexibility and failed to adequately address concerns raised by “member countries representing more than 70 percent of European shipping [Greece represents about 60 percent of the EU fleet].” He also warned that “rigid approaches” could undermine the chances of an IMO deal.

Panama and Liberia duo: The Panama-Liberia alternative provides no mandatory emissions pricing, no remedial-unit payments and no central Net-Zero Fund. Instead, ships would balance deficits using surplus units, while emissions targets would follow fuels that are already commercially viable — based on their price, availability and scale — rather than attempting to force new fuels onto the market. This proposal was publicly supported by Greek shippers in late August.

China seeks middle ground: Beijing has proposed making the framework more flexible without committing to either of the main camps. Its amendments broaden emissions calculations and replace fixed financial rewards with more general “incentive measures,” according to a non public submission seen by Martina. China has also separately proposed alternative ways of rewarding cleaner fuels if cash from the fund proves insufficient.

Brazil says delay: Brazil offered a more moderate rewrite that keeps the two-tier targets, compliance payments, surplus-unit trading, central fund and rewards for zero- and near-zero-emission fuels. But implementation would start later and early targets would be softer, making it essentially a delayed and weakened version of the existing framework rather than a replacement.

Other options: Japan would scrap mandatory payments and the central fund in favour of contributions to approved decarbonization projects, while also softening near-term targets. Saudi Arabia and the UAE, meanwhile, want targets tied more closely to the affordability and availability of fuels, and Norway is advocating flexible compliance.

MARITIME

RUSSIA PITCHES ITS ARCTIC ALTERNATIVE: Moscow is casting growing traffic along its Northern Sea Route as the beginning of a new phase for Arctic shipping, with Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov saying Monday that China’s first regular container services are only the start — and claiming interest even from countries that have joined Western sanctions against Russia.

China leads the way: Beijing is already Moscow’s main partner on the route, but Lavrov also singled out India and said South Korea and Singapore have shown interest in individual Arctic projects despite participating in sanctions against Russia.

Why Europe should care: The pitch comes as disruptions in the Red Sea and Strait of Hormuz increase the appeal of alternative Asia-Europe routes. The Northern Sea Route can substantially shorten journeys

to Northern Europe, but unlike Suez, the commercially important stretch runs through waters where Moscow controls access and permits — potentially giving Russia new leverage over an increasingly useful trade corridor.

Awkward timing: Lavrov's intervention lands as the Commission holds its Arctic Forum today and works on an overhaul of EU Arctic policy, expected in the coming months. Moscow, meanwhile, is making clear it intends to press ahead with an Arctic transport network built around China and other non-Western partners even if broader cooperation with Europe remains frozen.

CARS

VW UNION WARNS OF 'CONFLICT': CEO Oliver Blume goes before the automaker's board on Friday to again pitch his cost-saving plan that would cut at least 100,000 jobs and potentially shutter four factories across Europe. The workers' union made clear that it's not going down without a fight. "The signs are pointing to conflict," said Thorsten Gröger, IG Metall's regional director for Lower Saxony, the German state where VW is headquartered.

It wasn't us: Volkswagen management is "provoking a confrontation that we do not want," Gröger told a local media outlet. "But of course we are preparing for them."

Remember: Blume spent much of last week going before workers across Volkswagen's plants, including those on the chopping block, to discuss the plans and why they are necessary. The visits didn't go well, with 10,000 employees booing him during his first visit at VW's main plant in Wolfsburg.

Don't ask: The union doesn't "have to offer anything," Gröger continued, because the group already agreed to cuts in 2024 with Volkswagen's management. Those cuts are the first tranche of 50,000 workers. Blume says an additional 50,000 cuts are needed as the automaker continues to lose market share in China and faces sluggish growth and more competition in Europe.

No work stoppage — yet: As part of the agreed upon deal, workers have a peace obligation until the end of the year that prevents them from stopping work altogether. But that could change in the new year, Gröger warned. What Blume is proposing is "disproportionate to the thoroughly problematic situation in the automotive industry," Gröger said. "You can see that there is obviously an attempt to use the opportunity to enforce things sustainably and lower standards that would not have been enforced in better times."

INTERNAL FIGHT BREWING AT MERCEDES UNION: Fellow German automaker Mercedes-Benz is in a similar battle with its workers, who have been told they will need to forfeit their 35-hour work weeks and put in the full 40 hours for the same pay. But the union is at odds with itself after workers lambasted an op-ed co-signed by IG Metall Chair Christiane Benner at the end of June that called for "an agenda for a sustainable Germany" that "reduces costs" and "increases the volume of work and productivity."

Not the job: The Mercedes workers are doing enough already and expect their union leader to defend them, "not publicly adopt argumentation patterns that employers have used for years to justify longer working hours," IG Metall representatives wrote in a letter to the union leadership that was obtained by our colleagues at WELT.

Helping the AfD: Benner's comments run counter to the union's position as a "countervailing power to the government," the letter said. If the union fails at the mission, "we will inevitably get a further rise of the AfD. Any further increase in votes for the AfD is a defeat for the entire workers' movement," the

letter continues, referring to the far-right Alternative for Germany party.

Elections looming: The AfD garnered 29 percent of the vote in 2024's Brandenburg state election and they are ahead in the polls for other state elections later this month. The crisis in the automotive industry has become a key talking point for the AfD, with the group blaming the current government's economic policies for the country's deindustrialization.

STELLANTIS CREATES FIRST TRADE ROLE: The French-American-Italian company announced on Monday that it has appointed Clara Ingen-Housz to head the company's regulatory and trade strategy, reporting directly to CEO Antonio Filosa. The role is a first for the automaker, with Ingen-Housz expected to develop Stellantis' "international trade law capability."

Reflection of the times: Stellantis, along with the rest of Europe's automakers, has been caught in the crossfire of U.S. President Donald Trump's trade war, particularly in North America, where automakers are now paying tariffs on parts and vehicles crossing the Mexican and Canadian borders into the U.S.

More coming: Hopes were high the U.S. and Canada would negotiate a deal on tariffs, but the talks fell through at the 11th hour. Instead of a reprieve, Trump is threatening to raise tariffs on cars and automotive parts from the current 25 percent to 50 percent on Jan. 1 of next year.

PIT STOPS

Planned rail closures in Romania and Serbia are raising concerns in Bulgaria that overlapping infrastructure works could choke freight routes linking Central Europe with the Balkans and Turkey. This has prompted Sofia to call for coordinated works and dedicated time slots to keep international freight trains moving.

Volvo cars announced it is closing its Stockholm office by Mar. 1, 2027 as it consolidates teams and resources. The 450 workers will be reassigned to headquarters in Gothenburg.

Headlines

Here's a recap of yesterday's news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

EU wants to convince China to curb exports to the bloc

The relationship between Brussels and Beijing will be best served "if this problem is being tackled from both sides," EU trade chief Maroš Šefčovič tells POLITICO.

By Camille Gijs · Aug 31, 2026, 08:12 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

Trump promises more strikes after US and Iran trade blows for first time in a month

Trump told Fox News in an interview Monday morning that the U.S. will hit Iran "hard" in response to the Iranian attack on U.S. forces overnight.

By Elleiana Green · Aug 31, 2026, 07:33 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

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